

## *Saudi Arabia: Houthi gains will force diplomatic response*

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### 【メール原文】

The Houthis have gained full operational control of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait after a rapid offensive against Saudi Arabia-backed Yemeni government for|||||||

Quick take

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Saudi cannot reverse Houthi seizure of Bab al-Mandeb, raising risk of oil disruptions

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

What Happened

The Houthis have gained full operational control of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait after a rapid offensive against Saudi Arabia-backed Yemeni government forces over the past 24 hours.

Our Take

Houthi control will drive a short-term spike in shipping risk and disrupt oil flows through the strait. The Houthis have materially improved their ability to harass commercial shipping transiting the Red Sea. The group can now target or threaten vessels with greater frequency and confidence, raising insurance costs and slowing traffic. Disruption will likely affect Saudi-linked flows most, but other crude and refined-product shipments will also face delays and rerouting to reduce the risk of Houthi attack. Elevated volatility is likely for roughly the next two to four weeks as regional diplomacy accelerates.

Saudi Arabia does not have an attractive military option to quickly reverse the new status quo. Riyadh's local partners along the Red Sea corridor have proven unreliable, with front-line forces effectively collapsing and southern factions showing little willingness to fight. A renewed Saudi escalation, while still possible, would risk mission creep and direct retaliation against Saudi infrastructure without a clear path to securing the waterway.

The kingdom also remains vulnerable to attacks by Iraqi Shia militias. Iran-backed Iraqi militias reportedly coordinate closely with the Houthis. A Saudi escalation against the Houthis would increase the risk of militia attacks against the kingdom.

Diplomacy will likely move faster than military escalation. Oman is best positioned to broker de-escalation. Iran will support its Houthi ally, though it is unlikely to become more directly involved, as it remains focused on its confrontation with the US over the Strait of Hormuz. Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, the Saudi minister of foreign affairs, is already engaging Omani counterparts, underscoring Riyadh's preference for a negotiated off-ramp. The US will support these efforts to negotiate with the Houthis and is unlikely to expand strikes to Yemen in the short term. However, any Houthi strikes on

transiting ships, especially US warships, as well as dramatic increases in oil prices, may drag the US into the fray. Over the longer term, the most plausible outcome is a Oman facilitated understanding that provides limited assurances for shipping through Bab al-Mandeb while leaving the Houthis with enduring leverage.

Houthi success will add pressure to oil prices. Saudi Arabia will face greater difficulties exporting oil from its terminal in Yanbu on the Red Sea, where volumes have already fallen from 4 million barrels per day (bpd) to 2 million-3 million bpd. Oil prices rose sharply on the news of the Houthi success, with Brent reaching \$107 per barrel, though a gloomy outlook on the US-Iran confrontation and signs that China's import demand may be recovering also contributed to the upward movement (see: Crude prices will exceed \$100 as the Middle East conflict drags on , 8 September 2026).

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